



the team to keep an eye on.

There is another asterix too. The top teams did not field a lot of their top players for their own reasons but my rebuttal to that is that a side can only face the opponent in front. If your top players don't show up for whatever reason, too bad. That worked in India's favour and we took advantage of it.

Now coming to the players. Sindhu had a good run. Coming off an injury layoff, Sindhu could ease into the tournament. Without the stiffest competition, she was able to get some wins easily to prepare her

First of many: The Indian women badminton players won the country's first BATC title, beating superpowers like China, Hong Kong, Japan and Thailand enroute to the top of the podium. PTI

in the run up to important tournaments like the All-England coming up soon. Gayathri Gopichand and Treesa Jolly were also coming back after injury hiccups. To be able to come and win against top players injects confidence. Ashwini Ponnappa and Tanisha Crasto were also in the mix. Ashmita Chaliha and Anmol Kharb, who played lower down the order, got a chance to play experienced and higher ranked opponents, like former world no.1 Nozomi Okuhara, from Japan.

It was a well-placed tournament in the calendar. The layout was great for us. Now, will this team go on to become world beaters at, say, the Uber Cup? We do have a great chance and I say that because if Sindhu strikes form, that presents a big opportunity for India. We also have two doubles pairs. Earlier, the order of play would be different with singles being our area of confidence. Now, we have two strong doubles options who can double up on the individual brackets. We have a chance at the Uber Cup, but it

certainly will be much more difficult.

The 2024 checklist

A long year lies ahead and keeping the increasing order of significance of the events lined up, a few elements need to be focused on. Everyone contributing and hitting form when it matters is one such aspect. The Uber Cup is a longer tournament with multiple ties. Each player plays an important role. The two benefits that players will take from this tournament is the confidence that comes from beating higher-ranked players and knowing that you can perform under pressure and do well. Seeing firsthand that it's possible to not crumble when things get hard means you go in without fear should such a situation happen again.

It might look like team events is where India thrives — look at the Thomas Cup triumph in 2022, the Mens Team silver medal at the recent Asian Games and now this win at the Asian Team

Top of the world: Treesa Jolly (L) and Gayatri Gopichand celebrate after winning against Thailand's Rawinda Prajongjai and Jongkolphan Kititharakul in their doubles finals match at the Badminton Asia Team Championships (BATC). AFP

